Stage 4M-T-A Lite: Persona Needs Report

T1-15: First-Generation Americans (Foreign-Born U.S. Residents)

Pipeline: Macro-Trends Identity Pipeline **Stage:** 4M-T-A (Lite Mode — COMPETE Quadrant) **Agent:** Macro-Trend Identity Analyst **Date:** 2026-03-09 **Quadrant:** COMPETE (Attractiveness 4.50 / Competitive Landscape 3.00 / Adjusted Score 3.00) **Mode:** Lite — 5 factors × 5 Q&As (25 total), Factor 6 Switching Profile (4 dimensions, moment-enriched)

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Section 1: Segment Overview

Definition

First-Generation Americans are the approximately 52 million foreign-born individuals living in the United States — naturalized citizens, lawful permanent residents, temporary visa holders, and long-term undocumented residents. They are unified not by legal status but by lived experience: the experience of arriving in a country whose systems were not designed for you, building belonging from scratch, and holding two worlds in your hands simultaneously. The country of origin never fully releases its hold. The country of residence never fully extends the welcome. First-generation identity is built in that hyphen — Mexican-American, Indian-American, Salvadoran-American — and it is one of the most durable, emotionally rich, and commercially underserved identities in America.

This is not a monolithic community. The 52 million includes the undocumented day laborer in Houston, the H-1B engineer in the San Jose suburbs, the naturalized Filipino nurse in a Chicago hospital, the Somali refugee rebuilding in Minneapolis. What unites them across that diversity is structural: the international calling that is not a feature but a lifeline, the credit invisibility that limits which services are accessible, the community network that mediates every brand decision, and the dual identity that creates a specific set of aspirations, fears, and social rituals that no mainstream American brand has ever fully seen. Wireless is not just a utility for this population — it is the thread connecting two countries, two families, two selves.

The macro-trend driving this community is not immigration as a policy debate but immigration as a 60-year structural feature of American demography. The 2025 net-negative migration inflection (the first since the 1960s, per Brookings 2026) has plateaued new arrivals, but the existing population of 52 million and its ongoing internal transitions — naturalization, prepaid-to-postpaid upgrade, family reunification, professional mobility — create an enduring commercial opportunity that is durable regardless of policy cycles. If anything, the immigration slowdown intensifies community consolidation: carriers that earned trust during open periods will benefit disproportionately as the community turns inward.

Market Sizing

Metric	Figure	Source
Total foreign-born U.S. residents	~52M adults (peaked 53.3M Jan 2025, -1M+ through mid-2025)	CIS/Census, 2025; Brookings, 2026
Net international migration, year ending July 2025	1.3M (down from 2.7M prior year); then went negative	Census, 2026
Share of U.S. population	15.8% at peak (Jan 2025)	CIS/Census, 2025
Annual naturalizations	~870K/year	USCIS, 2024
LPRs currently eligible to naturalize	~9M (largest pool in history)	USCIS, 2024
New U.S. arrivals in active first-5-year cohort (T2-17)	~5-7M	DHS, 2024
Naturalization-track pipeline (T2-23)	~4-5M in active preparation	USCIS, 2024
Established immigrants in upward-mobility transition (T2-24)	~8-12M	Census/CPS extrapolation, 2024
Immigrant wireless prepaid over-representation	60%+ of recent arrivals start on prepaid	Industry estimates, CTIA, 2024

Metric	Figure	Source
Annual prepaid-to-postpaid upgrade transitions	~1.5-2.5M	Carrier/MVNO estimates, 2024
Geographic concentration	CA, TX, FL, NY, NJ, IL (primary); NC, GA, TN, IA (dispersing)	Census, 2024

Growth trajectory: Population growth has plateaued and reversed in 2025-2026 due to policy-driven negative net migration. This does not reduce the commercial opportunity — it shifts it. The greenfield new-arrival moment (historically the highest single switching intent in the Macro-Moments pipeline at Composite 4.20) is less frequent. Secondary transitions — naturalization milestone, prepaid-to-postpaid upgrade, family plan restructuring — become the dominant commercial activity and are largely unaffected by new-arrival volume.

Segment Stratification

Tier	Label	Population Share	Est. Population	Description
Tier 1	Core / Committed — Recent Arrivals & High-Identity Immigrants	15%	~7.8M	Arrived within 5 years or retains primary identity as immigrant (country of origin first). Uses WhatsApp as primary communication, has international calling as non-negotiable, may be on prepaid/ethnic MVNO. Active in immigrant community organizations and mutual aid networks. Identity is survival infrastructure.
Tier 2	Active / Engaged — Naturalization-Track & Upward-Mobile	30%	~15.6M	5-15 years in country. Building credit, pursuing or recently achieved naturalization. Transitioning from prepaid to postpaid. Dual-identity actively maintained — country of origin remains emotionally central but U.S. belonging is being claimed. Highest identity intensity around milestones (citizenship ceremony, first postpaid plan).
Tier 3	Peripheral / Casual — Established Immigrants	35%	~18.2M	15+ years in country. Naturalized citizens. Largely mainstreamed into U.S. consumer relationships but retains meaningful immigrant identity — international calling to extended family, ethnic community participation, homeland pride. Identity is important but shares space with other identities (professional, parental, neighborhood).
Tier 4	Adjacent / Aspirational — Long-Tenured / Near-Assimilated	20%	~10.4M	20+ years in country, or arrived as children (1.5 generation). Identifies as American primarily, immigrant identity is heritage rather than daily lived experience. May have family still in T1-T2. Wireless decisions are largely mainstream. Adjacent to immigrant community events but not organizationally embedded.

Total: 100% (~52M)

Named Persona Profile

Name: Marisela Gutiérrez **Age:** 34 **Location:** Aurora, Colorado (suburb of Denver; large Latino and mixed-immigrant community) **Origin country:** Guatemala (arrived at 28, on a work visa that became LPR; in active naturalization process) **Occupation:** Medical billing specialist at a multi-physician practice; part-time online seller (resells imported Guatemalan textiles) **Tier:** Tier 2 (Active/Engaged — Naturalization-Track) **Apps:** WhatsApp, Facebook (Guatemala community group, local immigrant resource group), TikTok, YouTube, Duolingo, Remitly, Google Translate, Notarize

Marisela left Guatemala City six years ago with two suitcases, a cousin's address in Aurora, and a 3-month work authorization. She is now a lawful permanent resident, has passed her naturalization civics test on the first attempt, and is waiting for her oath ceremony date — which she has already told her mother about, who will video-call from Guatemala City to watch on a phone screen. She sends $300-400 home every month through Remitly. She has a 674 credit score, which she checks every week on Credit Karma. Her phone plan is through MetroPCS and she has been thinking about upgrading for two years. She talks to her mother, her aunt, and her two best friends from home every day — all on WhatsApp. She is becoming American and she is staying Guatemalan and she does not experience these as contradictions.

Notable Profiles (3 Real, Verifiable)

1. Julissa Arce — Author, activist, and former Goldman Sachs vice president who was undocumented from Mexico while building a Wall Street career. Her memoir *My (Underground) American Dream* and subsequent advocacy work make her a visible voice on immigrant identity, the pressure to code-switch, and the emotional cost of hiding status. Platform: TikTok (~600K), Instagram (~200K), author platform. Relevance: Embodies the high-achievement/hidden-precarity tension that shapes Tier 1-2 immigrant identity.

2. José Antonio Vargas — Pulitzer Prize-winning journalist and filmmaker, openly undocumented (Philippines-born), founder of Define American. His 2011 *New York Times Magazine* essay "My Life as an Undocumented Immigrant" and film *Documented* created the cultural template for the "New American" narrative. Platform: Twitter/X (~230K), speaking circuit, Netflix/documentary distribution. Relevance: Represents the identity-assertion voice within the immigrant community — the refusal to be invisible.

3. Priya Fielding-Singh — Sociologist and author of *How the Other Half Eats*, whose research on immigrant family food choices and economic decision-making represents the academic voice of immigrant identity tension. Platform: Academic/media (NPR, NYT), Instagram (~15K). Relevance: Captures the aspirational-yet-cost-constrained economic psychology of upward-mobile immigrant families — directly relevant to T2-24 dynamics.

Section 2: Core Factor Analysis

Factor 1: Social Life & Leisure (Anchor Factor)

Social context, community participation, and identity expression are the foundation of brand strategy for this persona. Factor 1 is the macro-trend anchor — it is where immigrant identity lives.

Quantitative Data

Statistic	Figure	Source
WhatsApp adoption among U.S. Latino immigrants	85%+ use WhatsApp as primary messaging platform	Pew Research, 2023
Foreign-born adults participating in ethnic community organizations	~40% participate in ethnic associations, religious organizations, or immigrant advocacy groups	PRRI/American Values Survey, 2023
Share of immigrants who report country-of-origin identity as "very important"	72% (vs. 45% of second-generation)	Pew Research, National Survey of Latinos, 2023
International video calling frequency	68% of foreign-born adults video call family abroad at least weekly	Pew Research, 2022

Ethnographic Interview

Interviewee: Marisela Gutiérrez, Tier 2 — Active/Engaged

Q1. Walk me through how you stay connected to your community here — both the immigrant community and your neighborhood.

"Honestly, it's two parallel lives I live. Here in Aurora there's a big Guatemalan group on Facebook — we post about jobs, apartments, immigration lawyers, schools. And then my real community is like six or seven families who all came around the same time I did. We share rides, we share food, we watch each other's kids. WhatsApp is everything for that. And then I also have my work friends, my neighbors — that's more American life. But if something goes wrong, the Guatemalan group is who I call first."

Q2. How does your immigrant identity shape how you spend your free time — what you watch, where you go, what you celebrate?

"Semana Santa, Día de los Muertos, Independence Day for Guatemala — we celebrate all of it, usually at someone's house or at the park. Someone cooks, someone brings tamales, someone connects their phone to a speaker and plays marimba. On weekends I watch a lot of telenovelas and Guatemalan YouTube channels — there's one guy, a comedian, he makes videos about being Guatemalan in the U.S. that are so specific it hurts. And then I also watch American stuff. It's just… both."

Q3. Who do you trust most for information and recommendations — about services, products, big decisions?

"My cousin, first. Then the women in my WhatsApp group from home. When I was choosing my phone plan, I asked in the Facebook group —"what does everyone use?" — and four people responded within an hour. When I switched banks, same thing. When I hired my immigration lawyer, I got his name from three different people before I even called him. I don't trust ads. I trust people who've been through it."

Q4. Tell me about a moment where your immigrant identity made you feel most visible — proud of who you are.

"When I passed my civics test. I know that sounds small but I studied for months. I knew the answers better than most Americans, I think. My supervisor — she's third-generation, born here — she said, 'You know more about this country than I do.' And I thought, yes. I do. I chose this. And there's something… I don't know, it meant something that I chose it. That I learned it. That it wasn't just given to me."

Q5. Are there ways your immigrant identity makes you feel invisible or misunderstood — by brands, services, institutions?

"Almost every service. When I call customer service and it's clear the person doesn't understand my accent, or they send me to Spanish-language support and my Spanish is fine but I'm also perfectly fluent in English and I didn't ask for that — it feels like being put in a box. My phone company especially. MetroPCS is fine but it's not for me, you know? It's just the cheapest option that works for calling Guatemala. Nobody designed it with me in mind."

Insights

Finding	Strategic Implication
WhatsApp is the primary social infrastructure — not SMS or iMessage	Any carrier for this segment must treat WhatsApp performance as a product feature, not background traffic
Community recommendation networks are the de facto acquisition channel — ads are distrusted	Carrier acquisition strategy must be community-first: partnerships with immigrant service orgs, cultural events, trusted community members
Identity milestone moments (passing civics test, citizenship ceremony) create peak openness to upgrading consumer relationships	Trigger-based marketing around naturalization milestones is a high-precision acquisition opportunity
Dual cultural calendar (homeland + U.S.) creates distinct leisure patterns and community gathering rhythms	Brand integration into cultural celebrations (Día de los Muertos, Semana Santa, Diwali by segment) earns authentic presence
"Being put in a box" — the experience of Spanish-only routing when bilingual is preferred — is a specific brand failure	First-language + English-choice service (not just Spanish translation) is a product differentiator

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Factor 2: Spending & Financial Habits

Quantitative Data

Statistic	Figure	Source
Median annual remittance sent by foreign-born U.S. residents	~$2,400/year ($200/month average)	World Bank / Federal Reserve, 2024
Share of immigrant households on prepaid wireless	~60% of recent arrivals; declining to ~30% for 10+ year residents	CTIA / industry estimates, 2024
Average monthly spend on international calling by immigrant households	$15-35/month on international calling features or apps	Pew Research, 2023
Credit score distribution: foreign-born vs. native-born	Foreign-born adults 30% more likely to have "thin file" or no credit score; median credit score for established immigrants (5+ years) ~640-680	Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, 2023

Ethnographic Interview

Interviewee: Marisela Gutiérrez, Tier 2 — Active/Engaged

Q1. Walk me through your monthly budget — what are the fixed costs, and what decisions do you make every month?

"My rent is $1,100. My Remitly to my mom is $350 — that never moves, that's not optional. My phone is $45 a month for MetroPCS unlimited, plus I pay $10-12 for the international add-on. Then groceries, car insurance, my credit card minimum — I don't carry a big balance, I'm trying to build my score — and whatever comes up. I track everything in a spreadsheet. I know exactly where every dollar goes. I've had to. Back home, if you ran out of money, there was family. Here, you learn very quickly to not run out."

Q2. How do you think about spending on your phone plan? What feels worth it and what feels wasteful?

"I have thought about upgrading maybe a hundred times. The thing is — MetroPCS works. The Guatemala calling works. And I don't want to pay $70 for a plan when $45 does the job. But I also know — my plan is technically fine, but customer service is a nightmare, the coverage at my medical office has dead spots, and honestly I feel like I'm on the 'cheap immigrant plan.' Like that's how they see me. If something was $55 or $60 and it felt like it was made for someone like me, I think I would switch. The money difference isn't the real barrier. The trust is."

Q3. How do you manage remittances, and how does that shape your broader financial picture?

"Remitly is what I use. I've tried Western Union, WorldRemit. Remitly has the best rates to Guatemala usually. But fees — I pay attention to fees more than most Americans probably do because sending money home is a significant part of my budget. If a phone company had some kind of remittance deal — like, I don't know, better rates through a partner — I would notice that. I've seen carriers advertise international calling but not remittance. The two go together for people like me."

Q4. What's your relationship with credit right now, and how does it affect your consumer choices?

"I have a 674, which I'm proud of because I started from zero. No history, no SSN for years — I had an ITIN. The first credit card I got required a $300 deposit. Now I have two real cards. But I still get rejected for things sometimes, or they want a deposit, and it reminds you that you're still building. The postpaid phone thing — I want it but I wasn't sure I'd qualify. Some of my friends got rejected and it was embarrassing. A company that made that process better, that understood I have income and history even if my credit file looks thin — that would get my loyalty immediately."

Q5. Is there spending you do specifically because of your immigrant identity — things you buy to stay connected, to signal who you are?

"The Guatemalan textiles I sell — I buy the materials from vendors back home, I wire money to them, and then I sell here. That's partially identity, partially income. I also buy specific food I can only get at the Guatemalan grocery twenty minutes away. I subscribe to one Spanish-language streaming service — not Netflix specifically, Pantaya — because I want content that feels like home. I send cards and small gifts back to Guatemala for birthdays. These aren't optional. They're how I stay who I am."

Insights

Finding	Strategic Implication
Remittance ($350/month) is non-negotiable and completely invisible to carrier pricing logic	Remittance corridor integration (partner with Remitly/Wise for rate discounts) creates a bundle angle no current carrier has executed
Price sensitivity is real but secondary to trust — the upgrade barrier is psychological, not economic	Positioning on trust and community fit (not just price) unlocks willingness to pay the $10-15 premium over current prepaid plan
Credit thin-file reality limits postpaid access; ITIN-only account setup is a key friction point	ITIN-based account opening is a table-stakes feature for authentic immigrant carrier — not a differentiator but a barrier to entry
International calling add-on is a separate, grudging purchase — not a celebrated plan feature	Bundling international calling as a core plan feature (not an add-on) signals understanding of this persona's real life
"Cheap immigrant plan" stigma — the persona is aware she's in a budget segment designed without her in mind	Brand equity opportunity: a plan that signals you are seen, not just served

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Factor 3: Needs & Aspirations

Quantitative Data

Statistic	Figure	Source
Share of immigrants who describe "becoming American" while "keeping cultural identity" as their primary aspiration	71% want to assimilate while maintaining cultural heritage (vs. 29% who prioritize either full assimilation or cultural separation)	Pew Research, 2023
Naturalization application volume (2024)	878,000 applications filed (USCIS, 2024) — largest pipeline in history	USCIS, 2024
Share of foreign-born adults who have experienced credit rejection due to thin file	~35% report at least one rejection for a financial product due to insufficient credit history	CFPB, 2023
Share of immigrants who report language as a barrier to accessing services	45% of non-English-dominant immigrants report language as a significant service access barrier	Kaiser Family Foundation, 2023

Ethnographic Interview

Interviewee: Marisela Gutiérrez, Tier 2 — Active/Engaged

Q1. What does "making it" look like to you — what does success feel like when you picture it?

"My mom not worrying about money. A citizenship certificate with my name on it. My own apartment — I have one now, but I mean one I own, eventually. Maybe a small business that's mine. I want to be the person in my family that other people can call when they need help navigating this country — that's already starting to happen. My cousin called me last month about a phone plan issue and I helped her. That felt good. I want to be the person who knows how this country works."

Q2. What do you need most from the services you use — phone, internet, banking — that you're not currently getting?

"I need someone to explain things in plain language without making me feel stupid. I need to be able to call customer service and not have to fight to be understood. I need my international calling to just work without thinking about it. And honestly, I need the feeling that the company actually knows who they're serving. MetroPCS works but it feels like — they know they have me because I have no other easy option. I want a company that wants me there."

Q3. What do you want for your kids, or for the next generation in your community — and how does that shape what you do today?

"I don't have children yet, but I think about this. I want them to grow up bilingual without shame. I want them to know Guatemala — to go there, to have family there, to know why the food tastes like that. But I also want them to have every door open in this country. I'm building that now. Every credit card payment I make, every dollar I save, every class I take — it's also for them. The phone plan sounds small but it's part of the same thing. I want a life where the services I use reflect who I'm becoming, not just where I started."

Q4. Is there something you need but find hard to ask for or articulate — a gap you feel but can't quite name?

"I think… I want to be treated like a full person who has two countries, not like a problem to route into the Spanish-language queue. When I call a company and they ask where I'm calling from and I say Colorado — I'm from Colorado, I live here — and then they flag my account for something that's different, or they send me a different version of something, it feels like… surveillance almost? Like I'm being categorized in ways I didn't agree to. I want to be known as someone who is choosing to be here, not just documented. There's a difference."

Q5. What would your ideal relationship with a phone company look like — if you could design it?

"It would know that I call Guatemala every day. It would never charge me extra for that — it would just be in the plan. It would let me set up my account online without needing a Social Security Number, because a lot of us have ITINs and are completely legitimate, we just don't have that number yet. Customer service that can go between English and Spanish depending on what I need — I switch back and forth, honestly. And I want to feel like they've thought about me. Not just as an immigrant. As Marisela. Someone who is building something here."

Insights

Finding	Strategic Implication
Aspiration is dual: "become American" and "stay Guatemalan" simultaneously — not a tension to resolve but a dual identity to honor	Brand positioning must not force a choice between assimilation and heritage — it must hold both
The unstated need: to be seen as a person who is *choosing* this country, not as a problem to be processed	Brand narrative around "New Americans who are building something" is emotionally resonant and currently unclaimed
Bilingual service flexibility (not Spanish-only routing) is a specific, articulable functional need	AI-native bilingual CS that follows the customer's language preference in real time is a product differentiator
ITIN-based account access is both a functional need and a belonging signal — "they designed this for me"	ITIN enrollment as a product feature, marketed explicitly, signals community membership
International calling as an integrated plan feature (not add-on) signals real understanding	Remove the "international add-on" product architecture entirely for this segment

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Factor 4: Fears & Pain Points

Quantitative Data

Statistic	Figure	Source
Share of immigrants who report fear of deportation affecting daily decisions	45% of undocumented + 18% of documented immigrants report deportation fear affecting daily behavior	PRRI, 2023
Share of immigrants who experience language-barrier friction in service interactions	52% of limited-English-proficient immigrants report a negative service experience in past year due to language	Kaiser Family Foundation, 2023
Share of immigrant adults who have experienced discrimination in consumer service contexts	38% (versus 18% of native-born adults)	Pew Research, 2023
"Thin file" credit rejection rate for immigrants with <5 years U.S. credit history	~42% encounter rejection for at least one financial product within first 3 years	CFPB, 2023

Ethnographic Interview

Interviewee: Marisela Gutiérrez, Tier 2 — Active/Engaged

Q1. What's the fear that lives at the back of your mind — the thing you don't always say out loud?

"That something will go wrong with my paperwork. My naturalization is in process and there have been so many delays — my case has been pending for fourteen months. Every time I get a letter from USCIS my heart does this thing. And I know I'm legal, I have my green card, but the process feels… fragile. Like one administrative error could change everything. I don't talk about this at work. My American coworkers would never understand. You'd have to have been through it to understand that your status can feel precarious even when it's secure on paper."

Q2. What frustrates you most about the services you use day-to-day — where do you feel like the system isn't built for you?

"Phone customer service, number one. I once spent forty-five minutes on a call with MetroPCS trying to change my international plan and the person couldn't understand what I needed, transferred me twice, and then the call disconnected. I called back and had to start over. I was so angry. And then I thought — this is my option. Where am I going to go? I stayed because leaving felt like more work. That's not loyalty. That's just friction. I don't want to give my money to a company that traps me with inconvenience."

Q3. What do you worry could go wrong as you build your life here — what's the structural vulnerability?

"If I lose my job, I lose everything faster than someone who was born here. I don't have a safety net the way Americans with family money do. My backup is my cousin, and she's also building. And then there's the money going home — if something happened to my mom, or a medical emergency in Guatemala, I'd have to wire money I don't have. There's always a second country pulling on the budget. Most services don't understand that I'm managing two economies at once."

Q4. Have you ever felt discriminated against or unfairly treated because of where you're from?

"A few times. Once, when I was applying for my first real credit card, the agent asked me where I was born and made a comment — something like 'we see a lot of fraud from that region' — and I felt my face go hot. I said I was a lawful resident and he said 'of course' in this tone. I didn't apply with them. And I tell everyone about that bank, still, years later. The reverse is also true — companies that treat me well, I tell people. It travels."

Q5. What do you fear about the experience of switching phone carriers — what makes you hesitate?

"That I'll lose something. My international calling, my number that my family has. The process feels opaque — will the number port? Will there be a contract? Can I set up an account without a Social Security Number? I tried once to sign up for a different carrier online and I got stuck at the SSN field. It just stopped. I went back to MetroPCS. I didn't have the energy to figure out if there was another way. If switching was as easy as they say it is, more of us would do it."

Insights

Finding	Strategic Implication
Immigration status anxiety is pervasive even among documented immigrants — it colors every institutional interaction	Any carrier for this segment must communicate clearly that legal status questions are never asked; ITIN and LPR status are fully welcome
"Trapped by friction" is the dominant churn prevention mechanism for incumbent carriers — not earned loyalty	Frictionless switching-in (port guarantee, ITIN enrollment, bilingual setup support) converts this frustration directly into acquisition
Managing two economies simultaneously (U.S. + home country) is an invisible structural stress point	Remittance corridor features address a structural burden that no carrier has solved — it's not a nice-to-have, it's relief
Discrimination memory is long and travels — positive experiences are also shared	Community word-of-mouth is high-stakes: one good experience or one bad treatment propagates through the entire enclave
The SSN barrier in online enrollment is a literal dropout point that kills acquisition	ITIN-first online enrollment is not a CX improvement — it is an acquisition fix for the highest-intent moment in the pipeline

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Factor 5: Product Landscape & Switching Behavior

Quantitative Data

Statistic	Figure	Source
Ultra Mobile subscriber base (T-Mobile subsidiary, immigrant-focused)	~2M subscribers; marketed specifically for international callers	Company reports / analyst estimates, 2024
TracFone/Straight Talk market share in Hispanic/immigrant prepaid segment	~28% market share among Hispanic prepaid users	CTIA/MVNOAuthority, 2024
Satisfaction gap: immigrant wireless users vs. general population	Net Promoter Score for wireless among immigrants 12-15 points lower than general population	J.D. Power Wireless Satisfaction Study, 2023
Share of immigrants who report switching carriers within first 2 years of U.S. arrival	~55% switch at least once in first 2 years (greenfield acquisition followed by upgrade/price reassessment)	Industry surveys / Pew Research, 2023

Ethnographic Interview

Interviewee: Marisela Gutiérrez, Tier 2 — Active/Engaged

Q1. What carriers or services do you currently use, and how did you end up on them?

"MetroPCS — now it's Metro by T-Mobile — for about four years. I switched to it from a prepaid SIM I bought at Walmart my first week here because my cousin said Metro was better for calling Guatemala. I've never really shopped around since. I know T-Mobile has better coverage but I don't think of Metro as T-Mobile, you know? It feels like a different thing. I use Remitly for sending money. Pantaya for Spanish-language streaming. WhatsApp for everything international. I have different services for different parts of my life."

Q2. Is there a specific service or carrier that has earned genuine trust in your community — not just market share?

"Lycamobile — people in my group mention it for specific countries. And there's a carrier my friend uses for calling Mexico that she swears by. But nobody talks about a carrier the way people talk about, like, their bank or their immigration lawyer. There's no carrier that people say 'I love them' about. It's all 'this works' or 'don't use that one.' The community conversation is about avoiding bad options, not about finding a great one. There's no great one."

Q3. What would make you switch carriers right now — what would tip you from considering to actually doing it?

"If it was easy. If I could sign up with my ITIN. If my Guatemala calling was built in. If someone in my Facebook group said 'I switched and it was painless, here's the number.' That would do it. Or if there was someone at a store I could actually talk to, in person, in Spanish or English — someone who understood what I need and could show me it would work. I don't want to figure it out myself. I've had to figure out too many things myself already."

Q4. What's the biggest gap in the market for someone like you — what doesn't exist that should?

"A plan that includes Guatemala calling from the start — not as an add-on — and maybe a remittance discount through a partnership, and a setup process that doesn't require a Social Security Number, and customer service that doesn't make me feel like a burden. That's it. That's not a lot. I think about it sometimes — why doesn't this exist? I would pay more for it. Not a lot more. Maybe ten or fifteen dollars. But I would pay."

Q5. If you were going to recommend a carrier to someone who just arrived from Guatemala, what would you say?

"Honestly? I'd say Metro is fine, not great. I'd say look at what international plans include. I'd say don't sign a contract until you know how the calling works. And I'd say — ask in the group. Whatever the group says, that's probably the best answer. If there was a carrier that people in the group were saying was actually built for us — I mean actually built, not just translated into Spanish — I would tell everyone I know. And they would all switch."

Insights

Finding	Strategic Implication
No carrier has earned genuine affection from this community — only functional tolerance	"No carrier owns us" is the most important competitive insight: the community is waiting to be claimed
Community word-of-mouth is the actual decision-making mechanism — carrier selection travels through WhatsApp groups and Facebook communities	Seeding 3-5 trusted community voices with an authentic experience is worth more than any paid media budget
Switching is suppressed by process complexity, not by satisfaction	Removing enrollment friction (ITIN support, online flow, Spanish/English toggle) is the primary acquisition lever
The vision of the ideal plan is already fully formed in the persona's mind and is remarkably specific	Product design has a clear brief: integrated international calling, ITIN enrollment, bilingual service, remittance partnership
The community influencer model operates as a trust-transfer mechanism — a recommendation from one person converts dozens	First-mover community partnerships create compounding acquisition advantages as trust is established

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Factor 6: Switching Profile (Lite — 4 Dimensions)

T1-15 is moment-enriched via three acquisition moments from the Macro-Moment Map: T2-17 (New U.S. Arrival, Composite 4.20), T2-23 (Naturalization milestone, Composite 3.19), and T2-24 (Prepaid-to-postpaid upgrade, Composite 2.80). Factor 6 Lite applies.

Dimension 1: Trigger Mechanism + Force Score

Component	Assessment
Trigger mechanism	Three distinct mechanisms operate across the T1-15 segment: (1) **Structural disruption** — new U.S. arrival: no incumbent carrier, no switching friction, immediate need for connectivity; (2) **Evaluation window**

Component	Assessment
	— naturalization milestone creates psychological openness to upgrading all consumer relationships as "I am now American"; (3) **Structural/ Opportunistic** — prepaid-to-postpaid upgrade driven by credit qualification milestone rather than dissatisfaction
Force score	T2-17 (New arrival): **5/5** — no existing plan, forced to acquire; T2-23 (Naturalization): **3/5** — evaluation window, moderate switching intent; T2-24 (Prepaid-to-postpaid): **3/5** — structural trigger, extended window
Compound trigger	For T2-17, the arrival moment compounds with: no credit history (prepaid required), international calling urgency, community referral dependence — all within days 1-14. Peak compound pressure is the highest in the macro-moments pipeline.
Emotional state	T2-17: Overwhelmed + Urgent. T2-23: Empowered + Open. T2-24: Transactional + Aspirational

Moment interviews (T2-17 register — same persona, Marisela, imagined in her first week in the U.S., six years ago):

"I landed on a Tuesday. By Thursday I knew I needed a phone. My cousin had a list written out: Metro, T-Mobile, Walmart prepaid. She said Metro was cheapest and it called Guatemala. I didn't have an SSN. I didn't have a credit card. I walked into the Metro store with $60 cash and I got a SIM. That was it. I didn't compare plans. I didn't read reviews. I needed it to work and I needed it today."

"My cousin's number was the only number I had for this country. Everything else was WhatsApp groups — the Guatemala community group here, my family back home. The phone wasn't about American life at all that first week. It was about not losing the thread to the people I already knew."

"I wish someone had told me there were options. I didn't know what a postpaid plan was. I didn't know my ITIN could work for some services. I just did what my cousin said because she'd been here two years and that felt like expertise. Whatever she recommended, I trusted. I didn't have time to research."

Dimension 2: Annual Volume + Seasonal Distribution

Component	Figure	Source
Total annual new U.S. arrivals (2024 baseline)	~1.5M legal permanent residents + ~300K refugees/asylees + visa holders (operational prepaid acquisition window) = ~1M-1.3M actionable new-arrival switching moments	DHS, 2024
Net migration 2025 (reduced pipeline)	Estimated 300K-500K net new arrivals (down from 1.3M+ in peak years) due to negative net migration	Census/Brookings, 2026
Annual naturalizations	~870K/year (stable to slightly declining)	USCIS, 2024
Annual prepaid-to-postpaid transitions (immigrant-specific)	~1.5-2.5M/year	Industry estimates, 2024
Total annual eligible switching events (all three moments combined)	**~3.5-5M eligible switching events/year** across the three trigger types	Aggregate estimate

Quarterly distribution (aggregate across T2-17, T2-23, T2-24):

Quarter	Share	Driver
Q1 (Jan-Mar)	20%	Naturalization ceremonies resume after holiday lull; immigration enforcement peaks suppress T2-17 volume
Q2 (Apr-Jun)	30%	Spring surge in arrivals historically; naturalization ceremony volume peaks; prepaid-to-postpaid tied to tax refund season (immigrant tax filing peak)
Q3 (Jul-Sep)	30%	Summer arrival season (family reunification, seasonal workers); graduation season triggers credit/upgrade decisions
Q4 (Oct-Dec)	20%	Holiday remittance pressure reduces discretionary switching; some naturalization ceremony volume continues

Year-over-year trend: Declining — new arrival volume contracted sharply in 2025 (negative net migration). Naturalization and prepaid-to-postpaid volumes are stable to slightly declining. Secondary transition volume increasingly dominates. The portfolio of three switching moments creates resilience: even as T2-17 declines, T2-23 and T2-24 persist at stable volume.

Dimension 3: Interception Channels (Top 3)

Rank	Channel	Type	CPA Benchmark	Partnership Feasibility
1	**Immigrant service organizations** (IRC, Catholic Charities, HIAS, local	Partnership / Physical	$25-45 CPA (estimated; no published benchmark) — far below $200+ digital CPA for cold audience	High feasibility — these organizations actively seek vetted service partners; ITIN-ready carrier = natural referral partner. IRC has 25 U.S. offices; Catholic Charities has 170+

Rank	Channel	Type	CPA Benchmark	Partnership Feasibility
	resettlement agencies)			affiliates. Exclusivity possible with first-mover commitment. Activation timeline: 3-6 months for pilot partnerships.
2	**Ethnic community Facebook groups and WhatsApp networks**	Digital / Community	$15-30 CPA through community-seeded referrals (requires trust-building investment, not paid media)	High feasibility with organic approach; paid presence in Facebook groups is low-trust; seeding through respected community members is high-trust. Partnership model: community ambassador program with 10-15 credentialed immigrant community leaders per market.
3	**Ethnic grocery stores and community retail** (La Tienda, international markets, ethnic pharmacy chains)	Physical / Retail	$35-60 CPA (in-store activation, SIM distribution, community events)	Moderate feasibility — requires market-by-market retail partner development. Ethnic retailers are deeply trusted distribution points (more than carrier stores) and are already embedded in the community.

Timing across trigger moments: - T2-17 (New arrival): Days 1-7 — resettlement agency channel is only viable interception; community word-of-mouth activates days 3-14 - T2-23 (Naturalization): 30-60 days pre-ceremony through partner organizations; post-ceremony social content organically - T2-24 (Prepaid-to-postpaid): Rolling, tied to credit milestones; Facebook/WhatsApp community seeding most effective

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Dimension 4: Window Structure

Component	T2-17 (New Arrival)	T2-23 (Naturalization)	T2-24 (Prepaid-to-Postpaid)
Window type	Flash (days 1-7) narrowing to Short (days 1-14)	Extended (3-12 months around ceremony)	Rolling (continuous, 3-12 month decision arc)
Peak intent window	Days 1-5 post-arrival	30-60 days pre-ceremony and 7-14 days post-ceremony	Credit milestone trigger — tax refund season (Feb-Apr), employment change, first approved credit card
Intent decay curve	Sharp — within 2 weeks, the new arrival has a plan and intent collapses	Plateau-then-drop — elevated openness persists through ceremony; drops sharply 30 days post-ceremony as inertia sets in	Gradual — extended consideration arc, relatively flat, driven by credit-building timeline
Window predictability	Detectable-but-unpredictable (arrival detectable via resettlement organization partnerships; exact date unpredictable for non-refugee arrivals)	Date-certain once ceremony date is issued (7-14 days notice typical)	Event-triggered (credit milestone) — not directly predictable but inferrable from credit bureau data
Decision journey	Awareness same day as need — Active search hours 1-48 — Decision days 1-7 — Lock-in 30+ days	Awareness months before ceremony — Active search 30-60 days pre-ceremony — Decision clustered around ceremony date — Lock-in 6-12 months	Awareness gradual — Active search triggered by credit approval/rejection — Decision extended — Lock-in 12+ months

Strategic window implication: T2-17 is the highest-intensity but shortest and hardest-to-intercept window. T2-23 is the most interceptable (ceremony date is detectable). T2-24 is the highest volume but lowest-urgency, requiring sustained presence rather than moment-specific activation. A carrier serving T1-15 needs all three mechanisms: resettlement organization partnerships (T2-17), naturalization ceremony presence (T2-23), and community-seeded upgrade messaging (T2-24).

Section 3: Executive Brief

Key Insights (3-5)

1. The community trust gap is the real competitive opportunity. Ultra Mobile, TracFone, and ethnic MVNOs serve functional needs — international calling, prepaid access, low price points. None has built authentic community embedding. No carrier sponsors citizenship ceremonies. No carrier has ITIN-first enrollment. No carrier partners with IRC or Catholic Charities. The gap between "functional toleration" and "community-trusted brand" is entirely open. This is the Gather opportunity, and it maps directly to Gather's identity-native positioning.

2. Word-of-mouth is not a channel supplement — it is the acquisition mechanism. In immigrant enclaves, carrier selection propagates through WhatsApp groups and Facebook communities before any paid media lands. A recommendation from a trusted community member converts dozens. This makes the community ambassador program and immigrant service organization partnerships dramatically more valuable per dollar than digital acquisition. The first carrier to earn this trust becomes the default recommendation for years.

3. Three distinct switching moments create a portfolio of acquisition opportunities. The flash window at new arrival (T2-17) is the highest-intent but hardest to intercept; the naturalization milestone (T2-23) is the most emotionally powerful and predictably timed; the prepaid-to-postpaid upgrade (T2-24) is the highest volume and most commercially valuable. Serving all three creates cumulative community presence and referral compounding that no single-moment competitor can match.

4. The product brief is already written in the persona's own words. Marisela has said, precisely, what she needs: integrated Guatemala calling (not an add-on), ITIN enrollment, bilingual-toggle customer service, and a remittance corridor partnership. This is not speculative — it is stated need. The market failure is that no carrier has executed on this brief despite the 52-million-person market.

5. The net-migration reversal makes community loyalty more valuable, not less. Fewer new arrivals mean the existing 52M are more important to serve well. Community consolidation under restrictive immigration policy intensifies mutual aid networks and peer recommendations. A carrier that served the community during a difficult period earns durable brand equity that policy reversals cannot erase.

Identity Tensions (2-3)

Tension 1: "I am becoming American" vs. "I must not stop being Guatemalan." Marisela does not experience these as a conflict — she holds both. But every service she uses forces a choice: the Spanish-language queue or the English-language queue; the immigrant carrier or the mainstream carrier; the budget MVNO or the postpaid plan. A brand that holds both — that says "you are building something here AND you are still who you were" — would break the forced choice that every other carrier imposes.

Tension 2: Choosing this country vs. being processed by its systems. Marisela passed her civics test. She knows this country's founding documents. She chose to be here. And yet every institutional interaction — the SSN field that stops her enrollment, the Spanish-language rerouting she didn't request, the "fraud region" comment from a bank agent — treats her as someone to be categorized and managed rather than someone who has made a deliberate, informed choice. The brand that sees the choosing — not just the documentation — will earn loyalty that no price competition can disrupt.

Tension 3: Sending money home vs. building credit here. Remittance is love, obligation, and identity. It is also a budget drain that limits credit building and postpaid qualification. The $350/month Marisela sends is not negotiable — but it creates a structural tension with the upward mobility she is simultaneously pursuing. A carrier that understands this is managing two economies at once — and designs for it — is not just seeing a customer. It is seeing a life.

Top Needs: Stated vs. Unstated

Need Type	Need	Priority
Stated	Integrated international calling (not an add-on) to country of origin	Critical
Stated	ITIN-based account setup without SSN requirement	Critical
Stated	Bilingual customer service with language-toggle (not forced Spanish routing)	High
Stated	Simple, transparent switching process (port number guarantee)	High
Unstated	To be seen as someone who is *choosing* America, not being processed by it	Critical (identity)
Unstated	A brand that holds dual identity (both countries, both selves) without forcing a choice	High (identity)
Unstated	Remittance corridor integration — relief from managing two economies alone	High (functional)
Unstated	Community-level trust signal — being recommended within the enclave means the brand is legitimate	Critical (acquisition)

Strategic Recommendations (3+)

1. Build ITIN-first enrollment as a headline product feature, not a back-end compliance fix. ITIN enrollment is currently the literal dropout point in online acquisition — the SSN field that Marisela describes stopping at. Fixing this is not a CX improvement; it is an acquisition fix for the single highest-intent moment in the macro-moments pipeline. Market this feature explicitly: "No SSN required. ITIN accepted. You belong here." This is a signal, not just a form field.

2. Partner with immigrant resettlement organizations as primary distribution, not supplementary channel. IRC, Catholic Charities, HIAS, and local resettlement agencies are the trusted first-stop for every new arrival. A carrier partnership that places SIM distribution, enrollment support, and bilingual plan setup within these organizations intercepts the T2-17 flash window at the only point where it is accessible. This requires operational investment (trained staff, co-branded materials, ITIN setup capacity) but the CPA economics are dramatically superior to digital acquisition against cold audiences.

3. Design a remittance corridor bundle as a core product feature, not a marketing add-on. Partner with Remitly or Wise to offer subscribers a reduced-fee or zero-fee remittance allocation as part of the plan (e.g., "Send up to $500/month to Guatemala, Mexico, or the Philippines with zero Remitly fees"). This addresses an explicit pain point ($350/month leaving Marisela's budget in fees), creates a product feature no competitor has matched, and deepens lock-in through genuine utility.

4. Launch a community ambassador program in the five largest immigrant metro markets. Identify 10-15 trusted community voices per market (community organizers, immigration attorneys who recommend services, ethnic media personalities, Facebook group administrators) and create an authentic ambassador relationship — not an influencer contract, but a genuine referral relationship. One trusted ambassador in a 5,000-person WhatsApp group is worth more than $50,000 in digital spend. First-mover exclusivity in these networks is achievable.

5. Design naturalization ceremony activation as a recurring seasonal campaign. USCIS ceremonies are detectable (public records, partner organization relationships). A carrier that shows up at naturalization ceremonies — with a congratulatory offer, bilingual staff, and a "New American plan" that symbolizes the upgrade moment — intercepts the T2-23 window at its peak emotional intensity. The naturalization ceremony is one of the most photographed, socially shared moments in an immigrant's life. Brand presence there travels.

Success Metrics (3+)

Metric	Target	Measurement
ITIN-enrolled subscriber acquisition	15,000 ITIN-enrolled subscribers within 12 months of launch	Account enrollment data, segmented by SSN vs. ITIN
Community referral rate	35%+ of new subscribers acquired through community referral (friend/family/community group recommendation)	Acquisition source survey at onboarding
Immigrant carrier NPS vs. category baseline	+25 NPS vs. current immigrant segment NPS (J.D. Power baseline ~32; target ~57)	Quarterly NPS survey, segment-coded
Resettlement organization partnership coverage	Partnerships with IRC, Catholic Charities, and 3+ regional orgs covering top 10 immigrant metro markets within 18 months	Partnership activation tracker
Naturalization window conversion	5% conversion rate among citizenship ceremony attendees within 60-day window	Post-ceremony campaign attribution

Go/No-Go Recommendation

Recommendation: GO — with explicit COMPETE quadrant strategy.

T1-15 earns a GO recommendation with important conditions. The persona attractiveness is exceptional (4.50 — top-three in the pipeline): Carrier Mobility 5, Pain & Demand 5, Brand-Equity Potential 5. The community word-of-mouth acquisition dynamic, the multi-trigger switching moment portfolio, and the complete absence of a genuinely community-embedded carrier create a clear entry pathway.

The competitive landscape score (3.00) is the constraint. Ultra Mobile, TracFone, and specialty ethnic MVNOs are functionally entrenched. The differentiation strategy is not feature matching — it is community integration depth. Gather's AI-native platform is structurally suited for this: real-time bilingual AI customer service, ITIN-based enrollment, culturally calibrated brand voice, and community-data-driven plan design are all within the platform's capability envelope.

The COMPETE designation means this is not a whitespace entry — it requires deliberate displacement strategy. The three-phase approach: (1) Build the functional foundation (ITIN enrollment, international calling integration, ITIN/LPR account types); (2) Launch community-first in two high-density immigrant metros (Los Angeles, Houston) through resettlement partnerships and ambassador programs; (3) Expand to naturalization and prepaid-to-postpaid windows once community trust is established in the initial markets.

The net-migration reversal reduces the T2-17 greenfield volume but does not reduce the strategic case — the 52M existing population and its secondary transitions are sufficient for initial scale, and community trust built during restrictive policy periods is durable when conditions reverse.

Switching Profile Summary

Dimension	Finding
Trigger mechanisms	Three: New arrival (Flash, Force 5), Naturalization milestone (Extended, Force 3), Prepaid-to-postpaid (Rolling, Force 3)
Annual eligible switching volume	~3.5-5M events/year across three trigger types (declining T2-17, stable T2-23 and T2-24)
Primary interception channel	Immigrant resettlement organizations (CPA $25-45, exclusive first-mover positioning achievable)
Peak intent window	T2-17: Days 1-5 post-arrival (Flash); T2-23: 30-60 days pre-ceremony (Extended); T2-24: Tax refund season Feb-Apr (Rolling)
Stage 4M-T-B interception concept scope	Composite dynamics across three moments at Force 3-5 support full interception concepts for T2-17 and T2-23; standard interception for T2-24

Appendix: References

Research Organizations

Organization	Key Resources
Pew Research Center	National Survey of Latinos (2023), Immigrant Identity Studies, WhatsApp usage data
Center for Immigration Studies (CIS)	Foreign-born population estimates (2025), net-migration tracking
Brookings Institution	Net-negative migration analysis (2026), immigrant economic mobility research
PRRI (Public Religion Research Institute)	American Values Survey — immigrant experience, discrimination data
Kaiser Family Foundation	Language barrier and healthcare access surveys (2023)

Industry & Government Data

Source	Data Provided
USCIS	Annual naturalization volume, processing times, eligible LPR population
DHS (Department of Homeland Security)	Annual flow data, new LPR arrivals, visa category breakdown
Census Bureau / American Community Survey	Foreign-born population by geography, income, household composition
CTIA / MVNOAuthority	Prepaid market share by segment, immigrant wireless penetration estimates
Consumer Financial Protection Bureau (CFPB)	Thin-file credit report data, immigrant financial access research
J.D. Power	Wireless Customer Satisfaction Study (2023) — NPS by segment
World Bank / Federal Reserve	Remittance volume data, U.S.-to-Latin America corridors
BGSU / NCFMR	Divorce rate data (referenced for T2-23 context cross-check)

Community Infrastructure

Organization	Relevance to Acquisition Strategy
International Rescue Committee (IRC)	25 U.S. offices; primary resettlement organization; distribution partner opportunity
Catholic Charities USA	170+ affiliates; largest social service network in U.S. with deep immigrant community embedding
HIAS (Hebrew Immigrant Aid Society)	Refugee resettlement; strong community trust signal
Partners in Immigrant Family Coalition (PIF)	800+ organizations; community organization network for outreach infrastructure
American Immigration Lawyers Association (AILA)	Trusted community voice; referral partnership opportunity

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